

Getting Rich Is Making You Poorer

- [1] You did everything right.
- [2] You worked hard. You got the raise. Maybe you got the promotion.
- [3] For about two weeks — maybe three — it felt like something had finally changed.
- [4] That specific relief. The sense that the number on your payslip matched the life you were supposed to have.
- [5] And then it faded.
- [6] Not the money. The money was still there.
- [7] But the feeling was gone. And you were back — stretched, anxious, never quite enough.
- [8] This is not a personal failure.
- [9] It is a mechanism. And the people who profit from it are hoping you never find its name.

— THE RAISE —

- [10] His name doesn't matter. He is every version of you that has ever gotten what you worked for.
- [11] Twenty-four years old. First real job. The salary felt enormous.
- [12] He upgraded his apartment. It made sense — he could afford it now.
- [13] He upgraded his car. It made sense — he was making more.
- [14] At twenty-eight, he got a promotion. Forty percent more than when he started.
- [15] He moved to a better neighbourhood. Better restaurants. Better clothes.
- [16] At thirty-two, he was earning three times what he earned at twenty-four.
- [17] He was also, quietly, more anxious about money than he had ever been in his life.
- [18] His lifestyle had grown to match every raise, every time, without a single conscious decision.
- [19] He was further from savings than he had been at twenty-four.
- [20] He could not explain it. The numbers said he should be fine.
- [21] The numbers were not the problem.

— THE MECHANISM —

- [22] Here is what was happening inside his brain.
- [23] The human brain does not measure wealth in absolute terms.
- [24] It measures wealth relative to a reference point.
- [25] That reference point is not fixed. It moves.
- [26] Every time your circumstances improve, your brain recalibrates what normal feels like.
- [27] The new apartment becomes the baseline. The new salary becomes the floor.
- [28] This is called hedonic adaptation.
- [29] It is not a flaw in your psychology. It is a feature.
- [30] For most of human history, this mechanism kept us alive.
- [31] When conditions improved, the brain stopped celebrating and started preparing for the next threat.
- [32] The problem is that it was never designed for a world where conditions can keep improving indefinitely.
- [33] In that world, the adaptation never stops.
- [34] And neither does the feeling that you need just a little more.

— THE TREADMILL —

- [35] There is a name for what he was running on.
- [36] The hedonic treadmill.
- [37] You run. The belt moves. You stay in exactly the same place.
- [38] Every raise, every upgrade — the belt adjusts to match your speed.
- [39] Lottery winners report, within eighteen months of the win, the same levels of financial anxiety they reported before.
- [40] Not worse. Not better. The same.
- [41] The money changed the circumstances. The brain changed the baseline.
- [42] The treadmill does not care how fast you run.
- [43] It only cares that you keep running.

— THE DIDEROT EFFECT —

- [44] In the eighteenth century, the French philosopher Denis Diderot received a gift: a beautiful scarlet robe.
- [45] He loved it.
- [46] He put it on and immediately noticed that everything else in his study looked shabby by comparison.
- [47] So he replaced his chair. Then his desk. Then the curtains. Then the art on the walls.
- [48] By the end, he had renovated the entire room — and gone into debt doing it.
- [49] He wrote about it himself. He called it a spiral he could not explain.
- [50] The name came later: the Diderot Effect.
- [51] One upgrade makes everything adjacent to it feel inadequate.
- [52] The new car makes the old garage unbearable. The new apartment makes the old furniture look wrong.
- [53] The raise that was supposed to create breathing room instead creates a new set of gaps to fill.
- [54] Your consumption does not grow in line with your income.
- [55] It grows in cascades.

— THE INDUSTRY —

- [56] None of this is accidental.
- [57] The consumer economy is calibrated to the reset.
- [58] It does not sell you things you need. It sells you the next version of your baseline.
- [59] Planned obsolescence ensures that what you own today feels inadequate within two years.
- [60] The subscription economy charges you monthly so each payment feels too small to cancel — while the total cost stays invisible.
- [61] Consumer credit exists to close the gap between what you earn and what the reset tells you that you should have.
- [62] The average household carries credit card debt not because of emergencies.
- [63] Because the lifestyle expanded before the income did.
- [64] Your bank does not want you to be financially free.
- [65] Financial freedom means you stop borrowing.
- [66] The product they are selling is the gap between your income and your reset.
- [67] The wider the gap, the more interest you pay.
- [68] The treadmill is not a metaphor. It is a business model.

— THE POPULAR MISREADING —

- [69] Everyone who understands this arrives at the same conclusion.
- [70] The solution is discipline. Willpower. Spend less.
- [71] That is not what happens.
- [72] Willpower is a finite resource. It depletes.
- [73] A strategy that requires you to constantly resist your own baseline fails the moment your attention is elsewhere.
- [74] The people who escape the treadmill do not do it by spending less through force.
- [75] They do it by changing what their brain registers as the reference point.
- [76] Not by earning more.
- [77] By deciding — in advance, automatically — what the baseline will not include.

— THE REAL CONCLUSION —

- [78] In 1974, the economist Richard Easterlin published a finding that became one of the most discussed in his field.
- [79] Across countries, across income levels, across decades — beyond a certain threshold, more money does not produce more wellbeing.
- [80] Countries that had grown significantly richer over thirty years showed no significant increase in reported happiness.
- [81] He called it the Easterlin Paradox.
- [82] The paradox is only a paradox if you believe money accumulates into wellbeing.
- [83] It does not. It accumulates into baseline.
- [84] Enough is not a number.
- [85] Enough is a decision.
- [86] The people who feel rich are not the ones with the most money.
- [87] They are the ones who stopped moving the finish line.
- [88] And they did it before the next raise arrived.

— EL MOVIMIENTO —

- [89] Here is what you do with this.
- [90] Automate ten percent of every payslip before it hits your account. Your baseline never sees it.
- [91] Next raise: freeze your lifestyle for one year. Bank the entire difference.
- [92] Check your bank statement right now. Cancel one subscription you forgot you had.
- [93] Build three months of expenses in a separate account you cannot see daily. That buffer kills more anxiety than any raise.
- [94] Raise your pension contribution by one percent this year. Over thirty years, that single percent compounds into more than most bonuses.

— THE ENDING —

- [95] You cannot stop the reset.
- [96] Your brain will always recalibrate.
- [97] But you can stop funding the next version of the baseline with money that should be building your future.
- [98] The treadmill runs whether you fight it or not.
- [99] The question is whether you are putting something aside before you step back on.
- [100] Every video on this channel is one way your financial gut has been engineered against you.

[101] This is how they turned your raise into their revenue.

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